

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת שמני
כג' ניסן תשפ"ו
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By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-אI תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini:
Did the AI get it right? Do you find

it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Rabosai, we find ourselves holding by Parshas Shemini, a parsha that starts with a gevaldig high and quickly descends into the ultimate tragedy. Aharon HaKohen finally brings the Shechinah to the Mishkan (Vayikra 9:23). Yet, immediately after, Nadav and Avihu decide to bring an aish zarah, an unauthorized fire, and are consumed by a heavenly fire (Vayikra 10:2). The meforshim argue over their exact aveirah. The Kli Yakar (Vayikra 10:2) suggests they were paskening a halacha in front of Moshe Rabbeinu. They were unquestionably tremendous tzaddikim, perhaps even greater than Moshe and Aharon, as Rashi (Vayikra 10:3) famously notes. But they lacked the basic mesorah of asking their rebbe. They felt a burning, spontaneous ruchniyus and assumed they could just innovate a new protocol for the Mishkan. It is like the yungerman who decides he knows better than the gabbai how to set the shul's thermostat—pure, unadulterated zeal, but ultimately resulting in everyone getting burned. Nadav and Avihu had the internal passion, the fiery kavanah, but they lacked the external discipline of ratzon Hashem which dictates that without a clear psak, all the inspiration in the world is just an aish zarah. In the second half of the parsha, the Torah shifts from the Mishkan to the halachos of kashrus, specifically the simanim of kosher animals: mafri parsah and maalas geirah (Vayikra 11:3). Why these specific simanim? The Midrash Tanchuma (Shemini 8) points out the hypocrisy of the chazir. The chazir lies down and stretches out its front legs, showing off its split hooves to the world, essentially declaring its perfect status. Yet, internally, it entirely lacks the maalas geirah. If Nadav and Avihu were a tragic case of internal fire lacking external conformity, the chazir is the exact opposite. It has the perfect external levush—the right hooves, the right hat, the appropriate shtetler—but inside, there is no maalas geirah, no chewing over the sugya, no internal digestion of ruchniyus. The chazir is the original master of optics. It goes through the motions of Yiddishkeit just to impress the tzibbur during kiddush, making sure everyone sees its split hooves before it devours the last slice of potato kugel. Both extremes are fatal to our avodas Hashem. You cannot survive on pure, unstructured internal fire without external boundaries, nor can you survive on an empty, superficial display of frumkeit without the internal emes. The **practical takeaway** for our kehillah is pashut. We need both the internal maalas geirah and the external mafri parsah, properly aligned with the mesorah. We cannot be like Nadav and Avihu, deciding that our own spontaneous inspiration overrides the established halacha. Nor can we be like the chazir, wearing the exact right uniform and proudly displaying our kosher hooves to the Rav while remaining completely hollow on the inside. The next time you find yourself standing by the bimah, ask yourself if your kavanah genuinely matches your levush. Are you truly digesting the divrei Torah, or are you just sticking your hooves out for the gabbai to see so you can secure a highly respectable aliyah on Shabbos morning? True avodas Hashem requires a perfect synthesis of both areas. We must follow the mesorah precisely, checking our egos at the door, and ensuring that our internal digestion of Torah seamlessly matches our outward dikduk b'mitzvos.

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With Cholent Kugel and Short Shuir

Attention Gentlemen
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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm **מנחה**

6:09/7:13 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

--- pm **מנחה - קבלת שבת**

7:31 pm שקיעה

4:57/5:11 am (16.1/72) עלות השחר

6:23:06 am נץ החמה

7:15 am **שחרית**

Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening

9:04/9:40 am ס"ז קריאת שמע

10:22/10:46 am ס"ז תפילה

12:57:16 pm חצות היום

1:30:22 pm מנחה גדולה (30)

4:47:34 pm מנחה קטנה (גר"א)

6:09:45 pm פלג המנחה (גר"א)

--- pm **מנחה**

7:32 pm שקיעה

8:14/8:22 pm (8.5/50) צה"כ ר' משה

8:24 pm **מעריב (52)**

8:32/8:44 pm (60/72) צה"כ



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm **מנחה**

6:15/7:20 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

7:38 pm שקיעה

7:15 am **שחרית**

7:39 pm שקיעה

8:31 pm **מעריב (52)**

This Week's Riddle

Riddle: What person appears in this parsha, but appears only one other time in the entire Torah?

Answer: Misha'el the son of Uziel appears in this Parsha (Vayikra 10:4) and in Parshas Va'era (Shemos 6:22).



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משל ונמשל ב-א' תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Imagine, Rabosai, a wealthy gevir who marries off his daughter to a top bachur from Lakewood. For the chasunah, the shvigger decides she must buy the young couple the most magnificent piece of silver for their kredenz to show off. She goes to an overpriced silversmith in Boro Park and commissions a solid silver becher. The silversmith pours a massive block of sterling silver, carves the outside with incredibly intricate designs of the Shivvas HaMinim, and polishes it until it is blinding. There is only one minuscule issue with this breathtaking shtickel silver: the craftsman completely forgot to hollow out the inside. It is a solid block. The yungerman brings it home Friday afternoon, excitedly pours the aged yayin, and watches in horror as the grape juice splashes right off the flat top, completely ruining his freshly pressed white shirt. Next to this useless masterpiece sits a fifty-cent disposable plastic cup. The plastic cup is objectively worthless, devoid of any intrinsic material value or yichus. Yet, when the yungerman pours the yayin into the cheap cup, it miraculously holds the liquid perfectly. The solid silver piece, for all its external beauty, is practically an expensive paperweight, while the cheap, hollow cup actually functions as a true kli, ready to be used for Kiddush to bring kedushah into the home.

Nimshal: In Parshas Shemini, the Torah introduces the intricate halachos of tumah and taharah regarding various kelim. The Torah specifically singles out a kli cheres and states explicitly that if a sheretz falls into its airspace, everything inside becomes tamei (Vayikra 11:33). The Gemara (Chullin 24b) and Rashi (Vayikra 11:33) derive a fascinating yesod from this verse: a kli cheres only contracts tumah from its toch, its internal airspace, but absolutely never from its gav, its outside exterior. Why? Because unlike a kli mateches, which is made of expensive metal and has intrinsic material value regardless of its shape, a kli cheres is literally just baked mud. It possesses no intrinsic value in its physical substance. Its entire chashivus as a kli, its entire halachic identity as a functional vessel, is defined solely by its toch—its emptiness and its capacity to hold something else within it. If it has no inside, it is just a heavy clod of dirt. Rabosai, the nimshal here is glaringly obvious. Every single one of us is fundamentally a kli cheres, formed from the simple afar of the earth. We often delude ourselves into thinking we are a fancy kli mateches, possessing tremendous intrinsic value because of our impressive yichus or our sophisticated understanding of shul politics. But the emes is that our true chashivus does not come from our external substance. If a person is completely full of himself, solid with his own gaavah like that silver becher, he has no makom left to receive anything spiritual. Our only true worth comes from our humility and our ability to make ourselves into an empty vessel capable of holding Torah.

Practical Takeaway: The practical takeaway for our kehillah is that we need to spend less time aggressively polishing our external silver and more time hollowing out our internal kli. We have congregants who will fight for a seat by the mizrach vante with the unrelenting ferocity of a hungry lion, completely convinced of their own towering chashivus. Yet, their internal capacity to simply listen to another Yid is completely non-existent. You simply cannot pour the holy yayin of Torah into a head that is already completely filled to the brim with ego and self-importance; it just splashes back and ruins everyone else's peaceful Shabbos. If you walk into shul and expect the gabbai to treat you like a solid gold kli mateches just because you pledged a few dollars to the building fund, you are missing the point of avodas Hashem. We must actively strive to cultivate the quiet humility of the kli cheres. The next time you feel slighted because you only got shlishi instead of shishi, or because the hot potato kugel ran out right before you reached the front of the kiddush line, remind yourself that a vessel full of itself is fundamentally useless. Make yourself completely hollow, empty your heart of all the ridiculous gaavah, and allow the Ribbono Shel Olam to actually fill your toch with authentic kedushah.

GOOD SHABBUS!